

01

CATALOG ENTRY · MAJOR FAMILY

The Major Seventh Chord with 9



FORMULA

Root · 3 · 5 · 7 · 9 — the major triad with a major seventh and a major ninth on top.

SOUND

The ninth adds extra warmth to the major triad with a major seventh — open, lush, unmistakably bossa.

WHERE YOU'LL HEAR IT

The first chord of **The Girl from Ipanema** — and the opening chord of countless bossa nova standards since.

CROSS-REFERENCE

Used in the repertoire examples on p.7 (Girl from Ipanema) and p.11 (Wave) — see Songbook section.

The Minor Seventh Chord with 9

The little sister of the Major9 chord — a bit more mellow, and at least as beautiful.



Drop the third of a plain m7 chord by a step and you land on the m9 — softer, rounder, and far less stark than its parent chord. Where the m7

can feel a little severe in isolation, the added ninth rounds out the voicing and gives it room to breathe, which is exactly why it shows up everywhere in jazz-leaning bossa nova writing.

The jazz bossa standard **Blue Bossa** makes extensive use of this chord — try comping through the changes slowly before bringing it up to tempo, and listen for how the ninth colours the line differently depending on what the melody is doing above it.

SUGGESTED PRACTICE PATTERN

The image shows a musical score for a practice pattern. It consists of a treble clef staff with a key signature of two flats (Bb and Eb). The pattern starts with a C minor 7(9) chord (C-Bb-Eb-G-A) and moves to an F minor 7(9) chord (F-Gb-Ab-Bb-C). The notation includes a guitar fretboard diagram for the Cm7(9) chord and a guitar fretboard diagram for the Fm7(9) chord. Below the staff is a tablature section with numbers 1-3 and 6-8 indicating fingerings for the chords.

LISTEN

Blue Bossa — Kenny Dorham / Joe Henderson. Note how the m9 sits under the melody in the A section.

TRY THIS

Play the pattern with your thumb only, then add fingerstyle arpeggiation once the shape feels secure.

RELATED

Compare with the plain m7 shell voicing (Shell Voicings booklet, p.1) — same family, different colour.

REPertoire EXAMPLE · 1 OF 7

The Girl from Ipanema

Bars 1-8 · built entirely from three chords in this catalog

CHORDS USED

01 Maj7(9) 02 m7(9) 08 Dom7(9)

FMaj7⁽⁹⁾ **G**7⁽⁹⁾

Tall and tan and young__ and love - ly, The Girl From I - pa - ne - ma goes walk - ing, and when

T
A
B

8 8 8 8 10 10 10 10
9 9 9 9 10 10 10 10
7 7 7 7 9 9 9 9
8 8 8 8 10 10 10 10

01 FMaj7(9) **08** G7(9)

Almost the entire A section alternates between just two voicings from this catalog — entry 01 and entry 08. Once those two shapes are comfortable, this song is largely a rhythm exercise rather than a chord-memorisation one.